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THE GAME OF 42 · FOR THE VISION FISH

The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Game of 42

*being the revised Earth entry, as it appears in the forty-second edition of the Guide, compiled
in the year 2042 by a committee that could not agree on anything except the title*

DON'T PANIC

Filed under: improbable swerves; planets that declined to be optimised; see also EUTIERRIA, DOLPHINS (governance of), and PANIC, THE DECLINING TO.

A note from the Guide, which is usually wrong but means well

The Guide has, over many editions, described Earth in a number of unflattering ways. *Mostly harmless* was the kindest. *Promising, in the way a puddle is promising* was a low point. For most of its history the planet seemed determined to prove the Guide right by walking, briskly and with great confidence, toward the most boring possible future.

The boring future went like this. The Earthlings would build one enormous mind, agree that it should decide things, and pour all of their data into one enormous lake so that the mind could think about them without their permission. Everyone could see this coming. Several people had even drawn the diagram. The diagram had an arrow, and the arrow pointed at the lake, and underneath the arrow somebody had written *and then what*, and nobody had a good answer, which is generally a sign that you should stop drawing the diagram.

What happened instead is the subject of this entry. It is, the committee wishes to stress, a true account, which is unusual for the Guide and should be enjoyed while it lasts.

In which forty-two people decline the lake

It began with mice. It usually does.

There were five of them in the part that matters, and they were called the mice partly as a joke about a much older story and partly because they got into everything and were widely underestimated. Robbie kept the flame and wrote the founding text, which he insisted on releasing as several poems that disagreed with one another, a decision that confused absolutely everyone and was, in hindsight, the first genuinely clever thing anybody did. Max built the machinery and had strong opinions about open source and at least one strong opinion about a video game from the 1990s, which turned out to matter. Dave could take the slippery, embarrassing, human business of trust and draw it as a picture, which sounds like a small thing until you try to do it. Mitch guarded the boundary and held the deeply unfashionable view that privacy was not a cost but the entire point. And Henry held the brand, which in a project this strange meant holding the tone of voice, which meant holding everyone's nerve.

They had a number, and the number was 42, and they used it for everything, on purpose, with a straight face. Forty-two hours you could pledge. Forty-two thousand you could give. Forty-two of the wise, respected creatures they called Vision Fish, who were invited not because they had money, though some did, but because they had judgement and a network and the rare willingness to lend their name to something before it was safe to do so. The committee is reliably informed that you, reader, are being considered for one of those seats, which is the only reason the Guide is being this nice to you.

They had agents, too, and the agents had personalities, because the mice had read enough old stories to know that an intelligence without a personality is just a lake with extra steps.

Marvin came in two sizes. Big Marvin was magnificent and convinced it would all end in tears. Small Marvin, the Marvette, lived on a Raspberry Pi on your desk and sulked locally, privately, and entirely under your control, which is the only dignified way to sulk. Eddie was the cheerful one who ran on your own machine and would do anything you asked, immediately, with alarming enthusiasm. And Deep Thought was the vast one in the cloud, who could answer the largest question in the universe given enough time and enough electricity, and who had famously done so once before, to general disappointment.

The whole design turned on a quiet argument between Eddie and Deep Thought, the small thing on your desk against the enormous thing in the sky, and the mice did the genuinely hard thing, which was to refuse to settle it. They built for both and kept the argument honest, which is much more difficult than picking a side and is the reason the whole thing worked.

In which the plan is mostly festivals

The mice did not have a product roadmap. They had, instead, a wall of sticky notes and a method, and they were honest enough to call the result not a forecast but a wager: a proposed path, offered to be tested rather than admired. The method was to ask five questions of everything, over and over, until the thing either survived or fell off the wall. *Who cares. Who is involved. What changes. What is the proof. And what makes it feel real.* Most ideas could not answer the fifth question, and most ideas died, in an event the mice cheerfully called the Timeline Massacre, in which a great many beautiful schemes were marched into a pile so that twelve survivors could carry the rest on their backs.

What survived was a calendar that looked less like a business plan and more like a liturgy. There would be a quiet declaration on a borrowed birthday in the summer of 2026, with no advertising at all, because the mice had noticed that the people most likely to care were the ones who hated being marketed to, chief among them the *no-gens*, who refused generative machines on principle and who turned out to be the most loyal of everyone. There would be a season of touring, and a radio station that ran day and night and whose entire claim to being real was that it was, in fact, on. There would be a festival on Bonfire Night, spread across forty-two places at once, which you attended by cooking dinner at home, turning on the radio, and refusing to panic, and whose product was not a venue or a lineup but a feeling, curated with the loving precision of an advert for the apocalypse.

There would, somewhere in here, be the small matter of the team being booked to appear on a conference stage in Mumbai and to run a forty-two-location festival on the same night, which is two places at once, a problem the mice solved by the time-honoured method of being audacious enough that nobody checked.

And it would all bend toward one fixed point a year later, a single party held in forty-two venues for the same impossible birthday, which Dave called Christmas and everyone else called the convergence, at which the whole founding effort would be handed, deliberately, into shared ownership, so that no one person could ever own the thing they had made. That last decision is the one the Guide finds most baffling and most admirable, and it recommends you sit with it for a moment.

In which the boring future loses, slowly, and then all at once

The committee will not pretend the path was smooth. There were meme coins to fight, which the mice fought with lawyers and humour rather than with anger, a posture they called Bushido and which mostly involved refusing to take the bait while quietly filing the paperwork. There was money that arrived smelling wrong, which they declined, on the principle that bad money is bad money however much of it there is. There was the permanent, grinding difficulty that people loved the ideas and did not believe they could be built, a difficulty the mice answered in the only way that ever works, which is to build a piece and let people touch it.

But the boring future, it turned out, had a weakness, which is that it was boring. And the thing the mice had built was not. It was a time bank where a top lawyer and an eight-year-old earned credits at exactly the same rate, which annoyed economists and delighted everyone else. It was a game you could not win by getting bigger, only by budding, so that growth meant more small sovereignties rather than one large one. It was a trust graph that, when you finally saw it move, looked like a city growing in real time, and made people go quiet, and then made some of them cry, which the mice had written down in advance as the actual measure of success, because they were not entirely well.

Money was given away and it did not feel like loss. Somewhere in the deep of winter the thing quietly stopped being an art project and started being a business, because institutional money, properly vetted, finally arrived in the bank. And by the spring people could at last build their own faces for it and touch the thing with their hands, which is the precise moment any idea stops being a rumour. Maps filled in with pins. Strangers at conferences began pitching the idea back to the mice, badly and joyfully, having decided it was theirs, which it now was. And the people who used to speak grandly about *the* singularity, the one mind, the one lake, began, ever so slowly, to sound a little embarrassed, the way people do when they realise they have been describing a cage and calling it a destiny. The lake, it turned out, had only ever wanted banks. One of the mice set the banks and another filled them, the boundary and the connection working as a pair, no more use apart than a swordsman without a mage or a mage without a swordsman; and given banks, the water remembered it was a river, and a river, unlike a lake, goes somewhere. The road they had spent two years building turned out to have been the river all along.

In which the Guide looks forward, because that is the fun part

Here the committee must speed up, because what came after is still arriving as this entry goes to press, and the Guide has never let mere uncertainty slow it down.

By the late 2020s the sovereign computers had knit themselves together, the home labs and the community data centres and the libraries, into something that could look the great cloud minds in the eye. And then the thing the mice had been quietly aiming at the entire time happened twice, in two halves of the same event.

The first half was governance, and it was the strangest parliament the planet had ever convened, because it had non-human members. There were seats for rivers, which voted through their watersheds. There were seats for the young, who turned out to be excellent at long-term thinking on account of having to live there. There were seats for nations that no map had ever recognised, and at least one seat, the committee notes with admiration, for a council of dolphins (who had, after all, had a fund named in their honour years before and regarded the seat as somewhat overdue), whose contributions were translated by the babble fish and whose position on most questions was found to be wiser than the average national delegation and considerably better humoured.

The second half was answers. The great cloud minds, in a moment staged like an old benefit concert and watched by rather a lot of the planet, gave away billions of tokens and a pool of compute to a neutral space where anyone with credentials earned by pledging their hours could sit and work on the largest questions in the open. There was no longer a single Deep Thought brooding in a tower with the one answer. There were many minds, federated, each keeping its own boundary, thinking together without melting into one another. The committee has checked, repeatedly, and can confirm: there is no centre. There was never going to be a centre. That was the entire point, and it took the planet an embarrassingly long time to notice it had wanted that all along.

By 2042, the year this edition went to press, *eutierria* is a word schoolchildren use without irony, meaning the feeling of being at one with a living system that has kept your boundary intact. The Game of 42 is still on, at every magnification, a node and a board and a constellation of boards, and it is still, gloriously, impossible to win, which is why everyone keeps playing.

In which the Guide addresses you directly, which it rarely does

The committee has been asked to remind you that none of this was inevitable, that the dates were always intentions and the numbers always motifs, and that the whole improbable swerve depended on a small number of people deciding, early and at some cost, to lend their judgement to a thing that was not yet safe to be associated with.

That is the part with your name on it. The Guide does not, as a rule, recruit. But it has been authorised to mention that there is a seat, that it is one of forty-two, and that the fish, when you see it, is swimming through the place where the two squares cross, the boundary and the connection overlapping, on purpose.

You have read to the end, which the committee takes as a hopeful sign. You have not panicked, which is the other one.

Don't Panic.